The Foundation
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1.2 Your First Folder

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Module 3: FOLDER ARCHI...

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4.3: Claude Desktop as a Thinking Partner

What You'll Get From This

You will stop using Claude Desktop like a vending machine and start using it as a thinking partner. You will work through a real problem, find an insight you did not have before, and understand when to think in Desktop and when to build in Code.

Video: Session 3 — Claude Desktop as a Thinking Partner

> Coming Soon

The Lesson

The mistake

Most people use Claude Desktop like a vending machine. Question in, answer out. "Write me a marketing plan." Claude gives you a document. You paste it somewhere. Done.

That works for simple tasks. But it wastes the most powerful thing Claude can do: think with you.

There is a difference between prompting for content and

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Prompting for content: "Write me a marketing plan." You get a document. It might be good. It might be generic. You will not know until you read it and by then you have already spent the tokens.

Module 4: CLAUDE CODE ...

4.1: Install and First Use

4.2: Claude Code in Practice

4.3: Claude Desktop as a Thin...

4.4 Making Claude Understan...

4.5: Where This Goes

SECTION 5: WHERE TO G...

Prompting for thinking: "I am trying to reach [audience] with [constraint]. What am I not seeing?" You get clarity. You get your own assumptions challenged. You get the blind spots surfaced before you build anything.

What Desktop excels at

Claude Desktop (the conversational interface) is the best tool for:

- Challenging your assumptions
- Finding blind spots in your plan
- Pressure-testing ideas before you commit
- Structuring messy thinking into something clear
- Exploring trade-offs between options

None of these require Claude to touch your files. They require Claude to think alongside you. The chat interface is built for exactly this.

Planning, then execution

Here is the workflow that saves the most time.

Without planning: You open Claude Code and start building. Halfway through you realize you are not sure what you actually want. You restart. You try a different approach. You restart again. Three restarts. Two hours.

With planning: You open Claude Desktop and spend 15 minutes thinking through the problem. What are you building? Who is it for? What does success look like? What are the trade-offs? You get clear. Then you open Claude Code and build it. One build. 30

The 15 minutes of thinking saves 90 minutes of building the wrong thing. Desktop for decisions. Code for execution.

Desktop Projects

Claude Desktop has a feature called Projects. You can give a Project your key documents, preferences, or background material. Every conversation you start inside that Project has that context already loaded.

This is the lightest version of "giving AI context about your work." If you did **1.2: Your First Folder**, you already understand the concept. Projects are the browser-based version of the same idea: persistent context that stays across conversations.

Think of Projects as the seed for what comes next in Session 4. They give Claude background. Session 4 (CLAUDE.md) gives Claude deep project understanding.

Tips

Desktop for decisions. Code for execution. If you are deciding what to build, use Desktop. If you are building it, use Code. If you try to decide and build at the same time, both suffer.

Start with what you are trying to accomplish, not what you want Claude to produce. "I need a marketing plan" is a product request. "I am trying to get 50 signups for a workshop in two weeks with no ad budget" is a problem. Claude is a better thinking partner when it knows the problem.

Push back on the first answer. "What is wrong with this?" "What am I missing?" "What would someone who disagrees with this say?" The first answer is often the obvious one. The second and third answers are where the value lives.

Conversations are disposable. The thinking is not. Do not treat a Claude conversation like a document to save. Treat it like a whiteboard session. The value is the insight you walk away with, not the transcript.

This is the exercise. Do it now.

1. Pick a real problem or decision you have been sitting on. Something you have been putting off or going back and forth on.

2. Open Claude Desktop. Do not ask "solve this." Ask "help me think through this."
3. Use the conversation to clarify your thinking. Push back on Claude's suggestions. Ask it what you are missing.
4. Write down the key insight or decision you reached.
5. (If you have time) Take one action item into Claude Code and execute it.

Conversation starters if you need them:

- "I am trying to decide between [A] and [B]. Here is my context: ..."
- "I have a plan for [X]. What am I not seeing?"
- "Here is a problem I keep running into: [describe]. What patterns do you notice?"

Go Deeper

- Desktop Projects are a lightweight version of the folder architecture from **1.2 Your First Folder**. If you want the full system, **Section 3** has the complete method.
- The prompting framework from **1.3 How to Structure Any Prompt** is running under all of this. When you prompt for thinking instead of content, you are shifting from Task-heavy prompts to Context-heavy prompts.
- The "plan before you build" principle shows up in **2.6 (Video as Code)**: the spec is where creative thinking lives, the build is execution. Same idea, different scale.

Next Up: 4.4 Making Claude Understand

You can think with Desktop and build with Code. But Claude still does not understand YOUR project. Session 4 fixes that with one file.

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24d • Lesson Check-Ins

Foundations 4.3 Check-In

You just used Claude Desktop as a thinking partner instead of a vending machine. Vote below, then tell us in the

Poll 52 members have voted

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